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Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Friday, February 20, 2026

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[00:01:34] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:02:38] Chamber.

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[00:04:13] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:05:29] Senate chamber.

[00:05:55] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:07:59] Chamber.

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[00:10:11] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:11:15] Chamber.

[00:14:09] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

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[00:16:54] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:17:35] Senate Chamber. This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

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[00:22:50] Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:24:56] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:28:01] Senate chamber.

[00:28:02] Be sure to stay connected with live sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's YouTube channel.

[00:29:48] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:30:40] Senate chamber.

[00:31:40] I start with that.

[00:33:14] The Senate will come to order. The senators will please take their seats. Those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will retire to the gallery. The senators and all in attendance will please stand if you are able.

[00:33:32] We will be led in prayer today by the Reverend Dr. Jeanetta Lee from St. Paul's Baptist Church in Richmond. And following the prayer, everyone will please remain standing. we will be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America by Senate Page Caroline Shoemaker of Williamsburg.

[00:33:52] Let us pray. Almighty God, we gather at the opening of this legislative session, mindful of the great responsibility entrusted to those who serve this commonwealth. From various traditions, backgrounds, and beliefs, we pause together in a spirit of humility, hope, and faith, seeking guidance that is higher than our own understanding.

[00:34:22] We thank these leaders for the sacrifice of their service. We ask our blessings over their families and homes. Grant these leaders clarity of mind, integrity of heart, and courage to pursue justice and the common good.

[00:34:40] Where there is disagreement, inspire respectful dialogue. Where there is uncertainty, grant patience and discernment. Help every decision made within these chambers reflect compassion, fairness, and a deep commitment to the dignity of all people.

[00:34:57] Bless this assembly with unity of purpose, even amid a diversity of thought. May wisdom guide debate, truth shape policy, and service remain at the center of all that is done here today.

[00:35:14] Keep a genuine desire to build a stronger and more just future ever before them. For the well-being of this body and all the communities they represent, we offer this prayer in a spirit of peace.

[00:35:30] Holy Father, we ask that you cause all to lock arms and march on until victory is won. Amen. I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for

[00:35:55] which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:36:34] Clerk will call the roll. All those present, please vote aye. The clerk will close the roll. We have a quorum, Madam President. Senate Journal for Thursday, February 19th, 2026.

[00:36:51] The Senator from Western Prince William moves that the reading of the journal be waived. All in favor of waiving the reading of the journal will record their vote aye, those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted?

[00:37:06] Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 38, noes 2. Ayes 38, nose 2, the reading of the journal is waived. The clerk will report any communication from the House of Delegates. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax.

[00:37:25] Good morning, Madam President. Good morning. Madam President, I move to waive the reading of the communication from the House of Delegates. The question is, shall the reading of the communication be waived? All in favor of waiving the reading of the communication from the House of Delegates will record their votes, aye.

[00:37:41] Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted, do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 14, noes 6.

[00:37:57] Ayes 34, noes 6. The reading of the communication is waived. The clerk will report any communications from the governor. We do not have any, Madam President.

[00:38:20] We've now arrived at the time in the morning hour when we recognize our distinguished guests who are joining us today in the gallery. I give my daily reminder about our procedure. A senator will rise and offer an introduction to their guest.

[00:38:37] I will then offer the welcome of the Senate. I ask that we all hold our applause until I've had the opportunity to provide the Senate's welcome. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Henrico.

[00:38:54] Thank you and good morning, Madam President. I rise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. It is with great pleasure that I introduce my dear friend and sister through service, the Reverend Dr. Jeanetta Lee, the Associate Minister of St. Paul's Baptist Church in Henrico, and I'd ask that she please stand.

[00:39:13] We're so grateful that she offered this morning's prayer. Reverend Dr. Lee has committed her life to service over the years, including leadership with Youth and Students Ministry, the Shepherd Staff, Outreach Ministry, and the Executive Council. Madam President, she has invested time in volunteering with the St. Paul's Community Foundation Board and holds membership in the Richmond Alumni Chapter of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority Incorporated.

[00:39:38] She is also the chair of the Religious Affairs Committee and a life member of the National Association of the Advancement of Colored People. And she has volunteered with the Henrico Police Department and is a former member of the Education Action Council with the United Way of Greater Richmond.

[00:39:54] Madam President, we are honored to recognize her as a faith leader whose ministry reflects a steadfast commitment to service, empowerment, and community upliftment. I would ask that you join me in giving her the warm welcome of the Senate.

[00:40:09] - Thank you, Senator, for that introduction, and welcome, Dr. Jeanette Lee. Thank you so much for all that you do, not just in your service to your faith community, but all that you do throughout the community in so many different ways. Your leadership is truly valued, And we are honored to have you here.

[00:40:28] Thank you for your words of prayer and blessing this morning. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the Reverend Dr. Jeanette Lee.

[00:40:45] The chair recognizes the senator from Hampton. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Visiting with us in the gallery is a distinguished group of individuals from the Minority Political Leadership Institute.

[00:41:02] MPLI is a division of the L. Douglas Wilder School of Government and Public Affairs at the Gracie Harris Leadership Institute at Virginia Commonwealth University. MPLI is a nine-month program designed to promote leadership development for individuals interested in issues important to minority communities including community economics, political climate, civic engagement, and equity. Participants of the program are here today not only as learners but as emerging leaders who will shape the policies and progress of Virginia in years to come. Please join me in welcoming the 2026 cohort of the Minority Political Leadership Institute as we express our

[00:41:39] gratitude for their dedication to the ideals of leadership and service. Thank you Senator for that introduction and welcome to the VCU Minority Political Leadership Institute. This cohort I know is remarkable. The series of skills and insights and expertise that you are bringing to the program is only strengthened by what you are learning and contributing to each other throughout your experience in MPLI. I'm so delighted that you've joined us today in the Senate gallery and I hope that as you continue through the program that you

[00:42:15] continue to grow and learn and also inspire each other. We look to you for your leadership, your continued leadership. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the VCU Minority Political Leadership Institute. The chair recognizes the senator from Hanover.

[00:42:41] Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I rise for the purposes of an introduction. The senator has the floor. Madam President, we have a group in the gallery of former pages from the class of 98. We have Marlene Colucci, Elizabeth Harris, and Erin Derby.

[00:42:59] And Madam President, with them is the parent of our current page, Our current page, Carolyn Shoemaker, and her mother, Ashton, is in the gallery. If you could offer them the warm welcome of the Senate and thank them for being with us today.

[00:43:16] Thank you, Senator, for that introduction, and welcome back to the Class of 1998 page program. We're so delighted to have you join us again, and we've just been really cherishing our time with our current pages.

[00:43:33] This is a remarkable group, as every class is, it's such an honor and delight to work with our pages every session, and we are happy to see you visiting us again, and we're delighted to have Ashton

Shoemaker here to recognize our Senate page, who just delivered the Pledge of Allegiance this morning.

[00:43:58] so delighted to see you all. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to Marlene, Elizabeth, Erin, and Ashton. Is there any other business for the morning hour? The clerk will

[00:44:25] call the calendar. Senate calendar for Friday, February 20th, 2026. We are awaiting House action on the bills from page one to page four. Uncontested calendar. House bills on second reading. The Senator from Eastern Fairfax. Madam President, I move that all the House bills on

[00:45:05] second reading on the uncontested and regular calendars, pages 4 through 19, House Bill 73 through 1499. The rules be suspended in the second constitutional reading of the titles be dispensed with. The question is, shall the rules be suspended in the second reading of the titles of House Bill bills on the uncontested and regular calendars, pages 4 through 19, House Bill 73 through House bill 1499 be dispensed with all in favor of that motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change

[00:45:42] their vote the clerk will close the roll ayes 40 nos 0. ayes 40 nos 0. the reading of the titles is dispensed with senator from eastern fairfax uh madam president ask all those bills goodbye for the day. The question is, shall the House bills on the uncontested and regular calendars now on third reading be passed by for the day? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The bills will go by for the

[00:46:18] day. Senator from Eastern Fairfax. Inquiry of the clerk. Does that complete today's calendar? Yes, sir. Is there any other business to come before the Senate? The chair recognizes the senior senator from Fairfax. The Senate will be in brief

[00:46:56] recess. For an additional 15 minutes the Senate Republicans will go back

[00:50:15] downstairs to chat about this list on our desk. The Senate will continue to be

[00:50:22] in recess. The Senate will return to order. The chair recognizes the senator

[01:47:59] from Hampton for the purpose of presenting the committee nominations report madam president i request that the committee nominations report on the senate standing committees be taken up the clerk will read the report 2026 standing committees february 20th 2026 version 2 on your pink paper agriculture conservation and natural resources marsden chair

[01:48:31] Obenshain, Stewart, Stanley, Suterland, Hackworth, Williams-Graves, Perry, Pekarski, French, Salim, Mulcahy, Rome, Srinivasan, and Bennett Parker. Commerce and Labor, Deeds Chair, Obenshain, Lucas, Marsden, Suravelle, Stanley, McDougall, Locke, Deestuff, McPike, Peek, Rouse, Bagby, Stewart and Boyce go courts of justice suravel chair open chain mcdougall deeds Stewart Stanley Boyce go peak Carol Foy Perry Saleem Pavola

[01:49:11] Sturdivant Srinivasan and Jones finance and appropriations Lucas chair deeds lock mcdougall open chain Stewart Reeves for vola suravel Mcpike Boyce go Pillion, Rouse, Bagby, and Ayard. General Laws and Technology, McPike Chair, Locke, Reeves, Pillion, Rouse, Head, Jordan, Van Valkenburg, Rome, Carol Foy, French, Craig, Williams Graves, Marsden,

[01:49:42] and Pokarski. Local Government, Ayard Chair, Stanley, McPike, Hackworth, Sturdivant, Van Valkenburg, Rome, William Scraves, Durant, Diggs, Pekarski, Srinivasan, Cyphers, Reeves, and Bennett Parker. Privileges and Elections, Roush Chair, Deeds, Hackworth, D-Stuff, Carol Foy, Durant, Perry, Diggs,

Saleem, Mulcahy, Cyphers, Jordan, Jones, William Scraves, and Bennett Parker. Transportation, Bagby Chair, Marsden, D-Stuff,

[01:50:20] Suterland, Boisco, Hackworth, Sturdivant, Ayrd, Rome, Diggs, Mulcahy, Srinivasan, Cyphers, Jones, and Bennett Parker. Rules. Locke, Chair. Lucas, Deeds, Marsden, Favola, McPike, Surabelle, Rouse, Thagby, Ben Valkenburg, Ayrd, McDougal, Killian, Craig, and Suterland. The chair recognizes the senator from Hampton. Madam President, I move that the committee nominations report be adopted. The The question is, shall the report be adopted?

[01:50:57] All in favor of the adoption of the report will record their votes aye. Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote?

[01:51:15] The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 23, no, zero. Ayes 23, no, zero. The committee nominations report is adopted.

[01:51:47] Is there any other business to come before the Senate? The chair recognizes the senior senator from Virginia Beach. - Thank you, Madam Chair. I'm sorry, thank you, Madam President.

[01:52:04] Madam President, I rise for a point of personal privilege. - The Senator has the floor. - Madam President, yesterday, the Virginia Assembly lost one of its finest public servants, and we lost a true friend with the passing of Delegate Barry Knight.

[01:52:21] Barry was a great man, great legislator, a true Virginia gentleman. He served the people of Virginia Beach with a steady, unshowy leadership. He showed up, he listened, and he did the work, and if you really want to understand Barry Knight, you don't start with his title, you start with his family and his heart.

[01:52:46] Barry was a devoted husband to his wife, Paula. The woman completed him. To Paula and the boys, he was Superman. He was a proud father to three sons, Hunter, Kyle, and Forrest. He wasn't just a dad, he was a mentor and a problem solver, a man you called when something needed to be figured out or fixed. And he was a grandfather to three wonderful grandchildren.

[01:53:16] He provided warmth, comfort, and to them, a jungle gym and a slide. He was also the kind of neighbor we wish we all had. The kind who would lend a hand without keeping score. If something broke, Barry would help fix it or walk you through how to fix it. He was a farmer first, famously the pig farmer from pungo he was shaped by hard seasons early mornings and the understanding that nothing worth having comes easy he produced food before he produced budgets he fed a whole lot of people

[01:53:55] over the years sometimes with food sometimes with policy sometimes with council and plenty times with a smile and a joke paired with a laugh that could not only be contained ever it was absolutely infectious as chairman he didn't treat power as something to display he treated it as responsibility he respected the numbers because he understood the projects and what needed to be accomplished

[01:54:27] when barry spoke he listened because he he was always something to learn from a man who had dirt under his fingernails and a command of the balance sheet he was also a proud man proud of where he came from, proud of his roots, proud of his heritage that reached back to the original settlers of Virginia. But his pride was an ego, it was stewardship. Barry believed you inherited more than land, you inherited responsibility to care for your people, your community, and

[01:55:02] the place you called home. Barry loved the outdoors, he was a great fisherman, and if you wanted to catch fish, you wanted to be next to Barry or on his boat. Let me rephrase that. Barry was going to catch the fish and you were going to watch with jealousy. He could find bonefish anywhere and he was going to catch them. He was also a great hunter. He loved to hunt. He loved to eat and he loved bringing others along for the stories, the laughter that came with it.

[01:55:34] And I'll tell you something about Barry. There was no piece of equipment he couldn't master. If he had an engine, a blade, a bucket, a hitch, or hydraulic lines, Barry could run it, Fix it, and more often than not, improve it.

[01:55:50] The only equipment I ever heard he had to be taught how to use was a helicopter. And even then, he figured it out before the lesson was over. Barry had a rare gift. He could talk to anybody. On the floor of the house, he was often a man of very few words.

[01:56:09] But if you were a friend, he never stopped talking, in the best way. He wanted to hear what you thought, and he wasn't shy about telling you what he thought. he was the kind he was kind to everyone and he meant it he didn't treat people like a problem to manage he treated them like neighbors or family to care for barry also loved to learn he loved to learn to research everything and anything he'd ask me what are you looking at when we talk about equipment say well what bobcat you looking at and i tell him and barry'd say hey isn't that the one

[01:56:47] with 115 horsepower isn't that the one with and he'd go through a list of attachments a list of everything and then we were looking at excavators we talked about excavators and he could fix anything he'd go you know in excavators no more than a diesel engine a pump a few hoses and a couple of cylinders and when you broke it down to that simple you understood barry a little better he'd do the homework he'd figure out what is the best way to spend your money or spend his money

[01:57:21] or spend the commonwealth's money he boiled it down to those simple facts and when he boiled it all together and put it back together and laid it out to you you were like he analyzed it he broke it down he put it back together where anyone and everybody could understand it he was a good friend to all of us in this body he had a special fondness from this with the senator from portsmouth we talked about him a lot. And we talked about her a lot. Barry truly loved her. And you could see in

[01:57:56] the way he greeted her, teased her, and always made time for her, it was the classic Barry. Loyal, warm, always ready, with a smile, a grin, and a joke. And Barry could never tell a joke without cracking up halfway through it. And then you just started laughing because he was laughing. You didn't even get the joke yet because he hadn't finished it and one of the stories so he told about the uh gentle lady and and my friend from portsmouth and this one always chokes me up a little bit he talks about when they went to lunch and as a pig farmer he would think that my friend

[01:58:35] our friend our beloved chairwoman of finance would order pork ribs nope she ordered lamb chops and barry didn't let her forget it well may we always remember his laugh his kindness his willingness to help everyone he loved the people he represented and he never forgot where he came from he'd always be willing to roll up his sleeves help fix any equipment you ever saw ever had or ever knew about and madam president he was just a true virginia virginia gentleman there are some

[01:59:14] people you can replace in a seat, but you cannot replace a man like Barry Knight. Barry, you'll be missed beyond words. You'll be missed, my friend. May you rest in peace. May we forever honor him

the best way possible in caring for our people the way he cared for hers. Rest easy, my friend.

[01:59:38] You earned it. Today, when we adjourn, Madam President, I'd like to adjourn with my friend, And our friend, our delegate, Barry Knight.

[01:59:56] The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. Point of personal privilege. Senator has the floor. Thank you, ladies. Thank you, Madam President. Ladies and gentlemen, Senator, I just wanted to note, I'm sure everybody's noted the Supreme Court then came down with a decision today.

[02:00:12] I'm not going to rub that in. But I do want to note that Justice Gorsuch wrote a very interesting opinion on that, I would commend everybody to look at because I think it's a good civics lesson and it's a good I think lesson for why all of us are here. I'm just gonna read one quick part of it which I think it I think applies equally to our chamber and not just the United States Congress but he points out that he understands today's decision will be disappointing. He said all I can offer those is that most major decisions affecting the rights and responsibilities of American people including the duty to pay taxes and tariffs are funneled through the

[02:00:50] legislative process for a reason. Yes, legislating can be hard and take time and And yes, it can be tempting to bypass Congress when some pressing problem arises, but the deliberative nature of the legislative process was the whole point of its design.

[02:01:05] Through that process, the nation, and I would say here in Virginia as well, can tap the combined wisdom of the people's elected representatives, not just that of one faction or one man. Their deliberative tempers impulse and compromise hammers out disagreements into workable solutions.

[02:01:23] And because laws must earn the broad support to survive the legislative process, they tend to endure allowing ordinary people plan their lives in ways that cannot when the rules shift from day to day. In all, the legislative process helps ensure that each of us has a stake in the laws that govern us in the nation's future.

[02:01:40] For some today, the weight of those virtues is apparent. For others, it may not seem so obvious, but if history is any guy, the tables will turn and the day will come when those disappointed by today's result will appreciate the legislative process for the bulwark of liberty that it is." So I never thought I'd be quoting Justice Gorsuch on the floor of the Senate, but I think today's opinion from the Supreme Court, U.S. Supreme Court, is a good lesson in civics for all of us, and a good example of why we are here doing the hard work that we do today.

[02:02:09] I just commend everybody to think about that over the weekend. Thank you, Madam President. The chair recognizes the senior senator from Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for an announcement. Senator has the floor. Thank you very, very much. The weekend. I think very shortly, Madam Clerk will be issuing a weather alert for some possible snow. What a great weekend to gather around with your family, start a fire, fix hot chocolate, and look for those checkbooks for the Massey Cancer Center.

[02:02:41] We're a little bit behind. It's halftime. We've got 13 in, need 27 to go, and I would appreciate your getting back next week, and let's get going on this and fight cancer. Thank you so much. Is there any other business to come before the Senate? The clerk will report any announcements on the desk. Sunday,

February 22nd, the Committee on Finance and Appropriations will meet in the Senate Finance and Appropriations Room to report the budget. Time to be determined.

[02:03:18] Monday, February 23rd, the Committee for Courts of Justice will meet at 8 a.m. in Senate Room A, GAB. The Committee on Local Government will meet at 8.30 a.m. in Senate Room B, GAB. The Education and Health Subcommittee on Higher Education will meet at 8.30 a.m. in Senate Room C, GAB.

[02:03:40] The Democratic caucus will meet 45 minutes before session in Senate Room 1 of the Capitol. The Republican caucus will meet 30 minutes before session in Senate Room 2 of the Capitol. The weekend weather report, today highs in the low 60s, showers and fog expected to turn into mostly sunny and breezy weather in the afternoon.

[02:04:05] Tonight, mainly clear skies with the low in the mid 40s. Saturday, partly cloudy for most of the day, with a high of 58 and lows reaching 30s. Cold rain is expected after midnight. Sunday, rain during the day, changing to snow in the afternoon.

[02:04:27] Highs in the 40s, light accumulations mainly on grassy surfaces possible. Snow showers moving into the night with the lows in the 30s. And as of today, the U.S. is second in total metal count.

[02:04:55] And if you've never watched curling, it's fascinating. I didn't have a clue what they were doing, but it was fascinating. The chair recognizes the senator from Portsmouth.

[02:05:15] Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I move that the Senate do now adjourn until 12 noon on Monday. And in so doing, that we do it in honor of my good friend, a friend to the General Assembly, and to the Commonwealth of Virginia, Barry Knight.

[02:05:33] The question is, shall the Senate adjourn until 12 noon on Monday, and that as we do, we adjourn in honor and memory of our friend and colleague, Delegate Barry Knight. All in favor of that motion, we'll say aye.

[02:05:51] Any opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. the senate stands adjourned until 12 noon monday be sure to stay connected with live sessions catch

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[02:06:31] this is the senate of virginia richmond virginia chamber this is the senate of virginia richmond

[02:10:40] virginia

